situation, whereas the civil government was marginalised, which found it convenient to acquiesce to it.

The Pak–US relations in the fight against terrorism remained fraught with mistrust. This sad state of affairs resulted in the difference of approaches and strategies to counter the TTP and Al Qaeda. Doubtlessly, these groups posed real danger to Pakistan and the world at large, and they could not be neutralised due to the lack of proper planned and sustained strategies. It needs to be understood that the combination of TTP and Al Qaeda was lethal and attracted worldwide attention. If Al Qaeda was not involved, the TTP and its activities, howsoever devastating within Pakistan, would not have bothered the US and the West. Moreover, if it had not been for the TTP, Pakistan would not have considered Al Qaeda a threat to Pakistan, at least in a direct manner.

Chapter 8 reviews the irritants and impediments that accelerated terrorism further. They undermined the strategies and policies against terrorism. The drone effects, the flared up Pashtun sentiments, myths and conspiracy theories – genuine, manufactured or invented – steadily increased. It helped the terrorists to spread their activities and gain ground.

Chapter 9 explains that insurgency and terrorism were flourishing in widespread religious extremism, which had undermined the economy, serenity and stability of Pakistan. People were fearful and the world was viewing Pakistan with suspicion, resulting in international isolation of the country. Ironically, the state response to handle the situation was lackadaisical. This situation was a serious threat to the stability of Pakistan. These elements operating jointly could be termed an existential threat to Pakistan. This finding gave birth to the existential threat theory, which has been elaborated in this chapter.

Chapter 10 explores the avenues and prospects of the early demise or dismemberment of the TTP. Some analysts thought that the TTP would miserably fail after the US forces withdrawal from Afghanistan. Others gloated prematurely over splintering of the TTP considering it the beginning of its end. Both scenarios seemed too imaginary and unrealistic. This approach of wishful reliance on the withdrawal of American forces from Afghanistan and waiting for Allah to set things right for Pakistan might not suffice.

It has been posited that the TTP and terrorism may not come to an end very soon due to several reasons. The resilience of terrorists and the lethargy of the state is an ideal recipe to perpetuate the palpable presence